

How Study Hacks Come to Life: Learners' Engagement Modes in Turning Short-Form Videos into Informal Learning Practices

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Short-form video platforms increasingly embed informal learning in everyday platform use, where learners encounter brief and visual learning content during routine browsing. Study hacks are a prominent example, packaging learning strategies as actionable techniques for improving study efficiency and performance. Yet little is known about how learners translate these generalized platform tips into personal learning practices. Based on semi-structured interviews with 15 regular viewers, this paper examines learners' motivations and challenges in applying such content. Findings show that learners move through platform-based triggering, saving-based filtering, contextual adaptation, and long-term practice adjustment. We identify four typical engagement modes and design opportunities to better support informal learning practices on social media.

CCS Concepts: • **Human-centered computing** → **User studies**.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: Social Media; Informal Learning; Short-Form Video

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1 Introduction

Informal learning often occurs in everyday contexts [1]. It is self-directed and lacks fixed instructional structures and evaluation mechanisms [39]. As social media becomes an important site for information access, informal learning is increasingly embedded in everyday platform use [7, 22, 24, 39]. This is particularly evident on short-form video platforms [5, 36], where brief, visually presented learning content routinely exposes users to strategies that can be applied beyond the platform [18, 32]. **Study hacks** are a particularly visible example of this content type [38]. These videos are usually grouped through hashtags such as #studyhacks and #studytoks [31], packaging learning strategies into actionable tips for improving efficiency, concentration, memory, or academic performance. They often compress complex strategies into decontextualized tips and frame them through promises of quick, replicable results [32], such as “How to Make an Academic Comeback in 7 Days.” These videos therefore offer a useful entry point for understanding how informal learning on social media moves from content exposure to practice. Despite their prevalence, little is known about how learners translate such generalized, platform-based tips into personal learning practices, or what challenges arise in doing so. To address this gap, we propose the following two research questions:

(1) How do learners use study-hack short-form videos to engage in informal learning?

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(2) What challenges do learners face when translating such content into personal learning practices?

To answer these questions, we conducted semi-structured interviews with 15 participants who regularly watched study-hack short-form videos and had attempted to apply them in their own learning. Findings show that learners' engagement was shaped by personal goals, platform cues, social feedback, and prior experience. They continuously filtered, adapted, and refined study hacks in practice, revealing an iterative process of evaluation and adaptation shaped by both personal experience and platform resources. Based on this process, we identify four recurring engagement modes and derive design opportunities for social media learning systems.

2 Related Work

Prior work has established social media as an important site for informal learning, where knowledge is delivered through decentralized participation, peer exchange, and self-organized social networks [9, 17, 28, 30]. Learners on social media platforms actively draw on others' experiences to observe, compare, and evaluate information, making social interaction a constitutive dimension of learning [7, 10, 20]. Yet learning on social media is also **platform-mediated**. Educational content reaches learners only after being filtered and structured through multiple factors, including algorithmic recommendation [3, 41], creator self-presentation [13, 14, 21] and credibility [26], visible engagement metrics [12, 27], content type (e.g., skill-based vs. information-based) [8, 16, 29, 35], and sense of community [4, 6, 19]. Learners also actively intervene in platform curation through their own information practices, such as saving, searching, rewatching [15, 23, 37, 40], and organizing content, which may further calibrate the recommendation systems [3, 11]. Together, these factors reflect **a sociotechnical environment in which platform structures, peer-generated social cues, and learners' own information practices jointly shape learning decisions** [2, 26]. Short-form video platforms intensify this dynamic, as content is brief, fragmented, and explicitly framed as actionable [5]. Prior studies have begun to examine how short-form videos move beyond online exposure and influence real-world behavior. Wang et al. have demonstrated how short-form video content can support a temporal pathway from online exposure to sustained habit formation in food practices [33, 34]. However, compared with food practices, study hacks are less materially bound, less immediately evaluable, and more dependent on learners' self-assessment, contextual adaptation, and long-term regulation. Overall, existing research still lacks a systematic understanding of how learners translate platform-mediated study hacks into situated learning practices.

3 Method

We conducted semi-structured interviews to understand participants' everyday engagement and challenges with study-hack short-form videos. The study was approved by the Ethics Committee at the authors' institution.

Participants. We recruited 15 Chinese viewers through a screening survey posted on Xiaohongshu. The survey screened for varied post-viewing behaviors, ranging from lightweight interactions to actual attempts (see Appendix A). This allowed us to also include partial, failed, and discontinued attempts. Participants (N = 15) were aged 18–30 (M = 22.3), and came from diverse academic backgrounds, spanning engineering, sciences, humanities, and related fields. Detailed demographic information is provided in Appendix C.

Data Collection. Interviews were conducted in Chinese via online meetings from March 28 to April 21. Each interview lasted 30–54 minutes (M = 44 minutes). Interviews examined intended, discontinued, and sustained attempts to apply study hacks, and probed the challenges and motivations in each case. The full interview protocol is provided in Appendix B. When available, participants shared relevant interface screenshots or usage traces with the researchers via WeChat after the interview. Recordings were transcribed, manually checked, and anonymized by the research team.

Data Analysis. We adopted a thematic coding approach. Two authors independently coded the transcripts and compared their initial codes through iterative discussion. Initial codes included categories such as algorithmic triggering, saving without revisiting, low-effort trial, abandonment, and staged restart. The coders discussed disagreements case by case, merged overlapping codes, and refined them into higher-level themes through consensus. We used mind mapping to organize themes, subthemes, and representative quotes into a hierarchical structure. These themes were further grouped into the four process-oriented finding themes reported below. Anonymized quotes are used to illustrate the findings.

4 Findings

4.1 Internal and External Triggers of Engagement

Learners' exposure to and attempts at study hacks emerged from the combined influence of personal goals, platform recommendations, emotional triggers, prior experience, and social feedback.

Goal-Driven Search for Practical Solutions. Some participants actively searched for study hacks in response to specific learning problems, such as distraction or difficulties with time management. They treated short-form video platforms as low-threshold repositories of strategies, where they could quickly find methods to try. As P1 explained, *"I get distracted really easily and didn't know what to do, so I searched for keywords."*

Platform-Triggered Curiosity and Anxiety. Some participants ($N = 5$) were motivated by the joint effect of *recommendation algorithms* and *creators' narrative framing*. Recommendation algorithms exposed users to relevant content even without a clear goal. On the one hand, such external input might prompt users to reassess their current state, generating anxiety or a sense of inadequacy that further triggers problem-oriented learning behavior. As P4 explained, *"I only thought about reviewing every day after watching the learning video. Otherwise, I probably wouldn't have done it. It was like a reminder and a push."* On the other hand, creators often framed learning advice through result-oriented, exaggerated, or novelty-driven narratives, which might stimulate users' impulse to try something new and uncertain. P6 said, *"I saw a video saying you should study while drinking, like Li Bai the poet. It sounded really wild. But it didn't really work for long. I just wanted to drink."*

Social Feedback as Collective Credibility Calibration. This motivation stems from visible social signals on platforms, such as likes, comments, and interaction feedback. Six participants mentioned the same methods, such as Hermann Ebbinghaus memory, Cornell note-taking strategies, and the Pomodoro technique. When referring to these methods, participants frequently described them as *"popular online,"* drawing on visible signals such as frequent mentions by different creators ($N = 2$) and large numbers of likes and saves ($N = 5$). Comments further supported more fine-grained evaluation by providing personalized accounts of use ($N = 11$), including corrections, additional details, highlighted takeaways, encouragement, and accounts of when a method did or did not fit particular learning situations. As P7 noted, *"I usually check the comments. If someone says it worked for them, I find it a bit more credible."*

Experience Reinforcement and Trust Accumulation. This builds on prior successful experiences. When users benefited from short-form video content, their trust in platform information increased, further raising their willingness to act. However, such trust could also make participants more willing to keep searching for a fitting method, even after repeated failures. P9 recalled watching a mathematics video for exams and finding that the creator explained the topic more clearly than her teacher, helping improve her score by dozens of points. Thus, even though she often failed to sustain other study hacks, she kept trying because she believed, *"I just haven't found the one that really fits me yet."*

4.2 Saving-Based Content Filtering

After encountering study hacks videos, participants often used **saving** as a lightweight marker of potential relevance rather than as a sign of actual adoption.

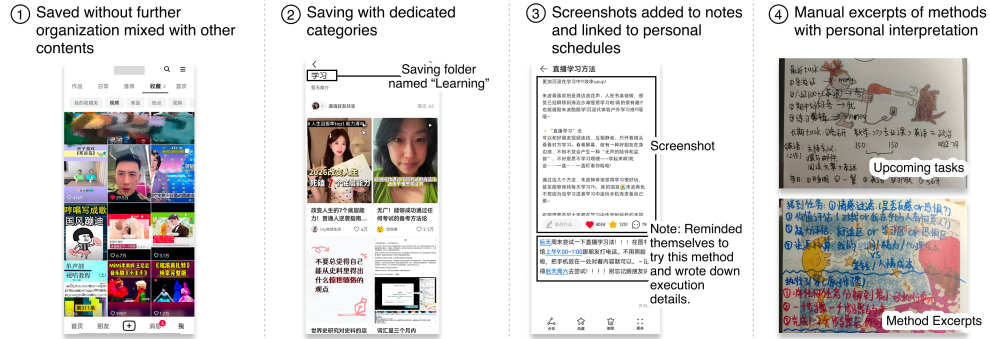


Fig. 1. Examples from participants' own materials illustrating diverse ways of organizing saved study-hack content.

Saving as a Marker of Delayed Action. Saving was one common way for learners to mark content as potentially relevant, but it did not necessarily indicate actual adoption (Figure 1 - ①, ②). Some participants revisited saved videos in later learning contexts and used them as an entry point for selecting methods ($N = 7$), while others saved large amounts of content but rarely reopened it, resulting in digital hoarding [25] ($N = 8$). As P13 put it, *"It probably just sits there gathering dust in my favorites."* For the latter group, saving mainly served to temporarily store content, ease the fear of missing out, or keep future possibilities open.

Multi-Layered Organization as Further Filtering. Some users further moved saved content into photo albums, memos, or note-taking tools (Figure 1 - ③, ④), creating a layered filtering structure that moves from coarse collection to finer selection. For example, P10 described a management routine that moves from *"favorites to photo albums to memos,"* noting, *"I usually look for what I need in my memos first."* Through cross-tool organization, participants actively compressed, reorganized, and filtered information to make it more retrievable as a future learning resource.

Searching as an Alternative to Revisiting. Some participants tended to re-search for relevant content when needed, using keywords or method impressions retained from earlier viewing ($N = 5$), because study-hack short-form videos are often structurally simple and topically homogeneous. As P13 explained, *"When I run into the same problem, I still search for new content. It is faster, and the content also gets updated."* As a result, saving often became an affective rather than functional practice, preserving a sense of future possibility without supporting actual retrieval.

4.3 Initial Trying and Contextual Adaptation

As participants moved into initial trying, contextual adaptation became a key step in determining whether a method could develop into sustained practice.

Broad Rapid Trial without Sufficient Adaptation. Some participants ($N = 3$) were more inclined to try many methods quickly. They could move from content exposure to action relatively fast and test multiple methods in a *"wide-net"* approach, but their prior adaptation judgment was often limited. They often only realized after practice began that a method did not fit their routine, resources, or abilities. For example, P9 mentioned that one video instructed them to get up at 6:30 a.m., whereas they usually got up at 7 a.m. at school and could not follow it. As the participant recalled, the creator had specifically emphasized, *"You should strictly follow the steps I share."* Such cases showed that rapid experimentation could help learners discover possibilities, but might also lead to rigid or poorly adapted attempts.

Partial Trying under High Implementation Costs. A different pattern appeared when participants only tried the simplest and lowest-cost parts of a method. Some participants ($N = 4$) were briefly triggered by content and believed that certain methods might be useful, but they avoided methods that required additional planning and sustained effort. Their engagement often remained at the stage of low-cost trying of the easiest executable parts. As P4 explained, “*I know that the Hermann Ebbinghaus memory method is useful, but it is too complex. You need to learn new material while reviewing old material as suggested.*” Here, the main breakdown laid in the method’s high implementation barrier and lack of stepwise guidance.

Selective Trying Supported by Experience-based Anticipation. Some participants ($N = 4$) drew on prior practice experience to judge in advance whether a study hack was a good fit. This anticipatory judgment developed through repeated trying, failure, and adjustment. As P14 explained when discussing how they assessed whether a method fit them, “*It’s all based on experience. I didn’t know whether a method fit me at first, but after getting it wrong enough times, I started to know.*” Over time, failed attempts became resources for judging future methods.

4.4 Long-Term Practice Adjustment

Users continuously adjust their learning pathways based on practice feedback, including continuing use, modifying methods, pausing practice, actively abandoning a method, or restarting it in future contexts.

Routinizing Learning Methods. For some participants ($N = 8$), persistence involved gradually integrating effective study hacks into their daily learning rhythms, turning them into stable personal habits, and using them to reflect on their learning practices. For example, P7 noted, “*I now write a reflection every night for eight months and find it really helpful. Looking back, I can see how my thinking about some problems has changed and improved.*” Some participants also extended such practice-based reflection back to the platform by sharing their own experiences in comment sections. For example, P3 explained, “*If I couldn’t find the original video but came across similar content again, I would share my experience. Everyone’s experience is really subjective. I also used to ask in the comments whether the method fit my own situation.*” Such sharing suggested that routinizing a method could also involve turning situated practice feedback into publicly available peer evaluations that future viewers might draw on.

Effective Interruption Based on Practice Feedback. Although some interruptions stemmed from high method difficulty, external distractions, limited energy, or unclear goals, others reflected users’ active judgments after short-term trials. Some participants ($N = 4$) observed whether a method worked within 3–7 days and stopped investing in it when it did not fit their routine, abilities, or learning goals. Here, interruption was an active way of revising methods.

Restarting as Reactivation under Cyclical Needs. Users’ motivation to act often rose during exams, holidays, or periods of task pressure, and faded as such pressure decreased, revealing a cyclical rather than continuous pattern of social media-based informal learning. Participants then reintroduced study hacks when motivation returned. As P11 noted, “*I do not have exams right now, but when finals come this semester, I will still use this method.*” Long-term practice therefore often involved returning to and revising methods across changing learning stages, reflecting the episodic way learners encounter and reuse short-form learning content.

5 Discussion: Typical Learning Engagement Modes and Design Opportunities

Although study-hack videos are often presented as readily actionable, our findings show that effective practice depends on how learners coordinate platform resources, including content, creators, and peer feedback, with their own learning contexts. Saving, selecting, trying, interrupting, and discarding strategies represent iterative evaluation and adjustment through which learners integrate fragmented online content into practice. We identify four engagement modes that capture different forms of coordination, each with distinct challenges, as shown in Figure 2. A learner may move

across modes or show different modes in different learning episodes, depending on their goals, filtering practices, and adaptation needs. ① **Steady** mode involves clear goals and precise filtering, enabling sustained practice but requiring ongoing filtering effort. ② **Cautious** mode involves extensive saving and evaluation, which supports careful decision-making but often delays action. ③ **Exploratory** mode involves active experimentation but faces challenges in filtering and adaptation. ④ **Passive** mode remains at superficial browsing, shaped by external triggers and limited internal motivation.

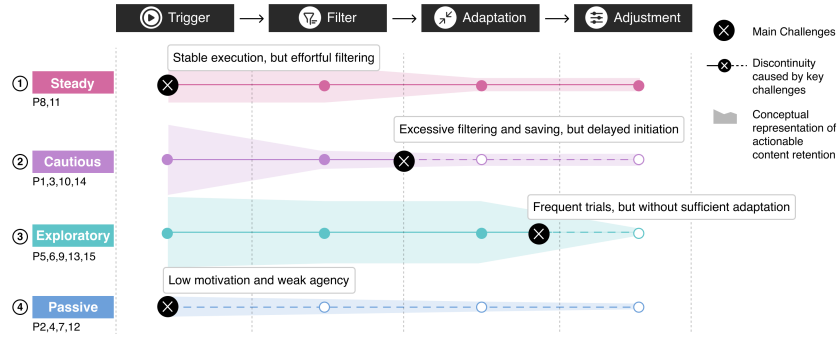


Fig. 2. Four recurring engagement modes with different challenges.

These engagement modes point to several support opportunities for future social media learning systems. For the **Steady** mode, the main opportunity lies in reducing repeated filtering work and helping learners compare, refine, and revisit methods over time. For the **Cautious** mode, support could focus on bridging the gap between saving and low-stakes trying, so that saved content does not remain only a marker of future intention. For the **Exploratory** mode, systems may help learners make trial outcomes more visible, for example by supporting reflection on why a method did or did not fit their context. For the **Passive** mode, the opportunity is less about recommending more methods than helping learners clarify whether a video addresses an actual learning need.

6 Limitations and Future Work

This study is limited by its small and demographically skewed sample, which was composed mainly of university students and female participants. Because participants had at least some prior experience engaging with or attempting study-hack videos, the study may underrepresent viewers who never moved beyond exposure, saving, or initial interest. The findings are also shaped by the Chinese short-form video context and may not directly generalize to other platforms or cultures. Because the study focused on Chinese social media users, we did not collect race or ethnicity data; future work should examine how such practices vary across cultural and platform contexts.

7 Conclusion

This paper shows that study-hack short-form videos are resources that learners actively work on to make learning methods usable in their own contexts. Learners filtered platform content, interpreted creators and peer feedback, adapted methods to local constraints, and revised or suspended practices as goals and pressures changed. By identifying four engagement modes, we show that social media-based informal learning is a negotiated and cyclical process, in which generalized tips become meaningful only through learners' situated efforts to test, modify, restart, and reassemble them into personal learning arrangements.

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A Screening Survey and Recruitment Criteria

“Study Hacks” Interview Participant Information Collection

Thank you for your interest in this study. This survey will collect basic information about you. After you complete the form, the researchers will contact you. All data will be used only for this research.

We are recruiting adults who have regularly watch learning-related short-form videos on social media and are willing to participate in an interview about how such content is translated into real-life action.

(1) Gender

- Male
- Female

(2) Age

(3) Educational Background

- Currently in associate degree / junior college
- Currently in undergraduate study

- Currently in master's study
- Currently in doctoral study
- Graduated with an associate degree / junior college degree
- Graduated with a bachelor's degree
- Graduated with a master's degree or above
- Other

(4) **Commonly Used Short-Video Viewing Platforms** (*Multiple choice*)

- Bilibili
- Douyin
- Xiaohongshu
- Weibo
- WeChat Channels
- Other

(5) **Which description best matches your viewing habits?**

- I occasionally encounter such content or have only had limited exposure to it.
- I often come across and watch such content.
- I often actively follow or search for such content, such as study bloggers or specific learning-related topics.

(6) **What do you usually do after watching such content?** (*Multiple choice*)

- I directly skip it without any follow-up action.
- I engage lightly with it, such as saving, liking, or commenting.
- I intentionally record it, such as saving it for later review or taking notes.
- I try to remind myself during daily life or learning, but do not actually put it into practice.
- I have actually tried the methods or techniques presented in the video.
- I have continued using the method and experienced some effects.

(7) **WeChat ID**

B Interview Protocol

Each interview began with an introduction to the study, informed consent, and demographic collection. We then asked open-ended questions about participants' viewing habits, reasons for engaging with study-hack videos, saving and organizing practices, experiences of translating videos into action, long-term habits they had maintained, and reasons for abandoning certain methods. Finally, participants were invited to share screenshots of their social media collections and other organization methods.

C Information of Participants

Table 1 summarizes participants' demographic information.

Table 1. Participant Demographic Information.

ID	Gender	Age	Education	Discipline
P1	Female	18	Vocational Education	Health Sciences
P2	Male	21	Associate Degree	Engineering and Technology
P3	Female	21	Associate Degree	Agriculture and Environmental Studies
P4	Male	21	Undergraduate	Business and Management
P5	Female	22	Undergraduate	Arts and Humanities
P6	Female	22	Undergraduate	Social Sciences
P7	Female	19	Undergraduate	Arts and Humanities
P8	Female	21	Undergraduate	Computer Science
P9	Female	20	Undergraduate	Arts and Humanities
P10	Female	21	Undergraduate	Engineering and Technology
P11	Female	30	Bachelor's Degree	Engineering and Technology
P12	Female	24	Bachelor's Degree	Food Science
P13	Female	26	Master's Degree	Business and Management
P14	Female	25	Doctoral Candidate	History
P15	Female	24	Doctoral Candidate	Education